



that changed the syntax of politics. It began with the arrival of Rajiv Gandhi and the charmed circle of his public school buddies in the tragic aftermath of Indira's assassination. A new power establishment was born, and it was different in its appearance, attitude and accent. The divide between the new elite and the traditional Indian political class defined by region and caste became glaring. There was a class difference, and there was no common language. When V.P. Singh left the Congress and floated the Jan Morcha, the attack on him was vicious. Said Rajiv in October 1989: "When I first saw the Raja (Singh) wearing a particular type of cap, I thought it was the cap of Maulana Azad but his recent actions have proved that the cap was Jinnah's." Singh's own party colleagues were not far behind. Taunted Yashwant Sinha, then a member of the Rajya Sabha and a Chandra Shekhar loyalist, "Government policies are like women's skirts. They go up and down according to changing fashions."

Some semblance of political dignity was, however, restored when P.V. Narasimha Rao took over as prime minister in 1991. He introduced the system of informal interaction with leaders of opposition parties. Politics returned to its worst instincts soon after his defeat and removal as

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Congress president. The entry of Sonia signalled another phase of decline in the quality of debate with all the opposition leaders attacking her on her Italian connection. BJP started its campaign in the name of "Ram Raj versus Rome Raj", and sometimes the attack was crude and personal. Gradually, she learnt to hit back. At her first public meeting in Delhi, she thundered while refuting charges against her husband on the Bofors payoff: "*Vajpayeeji jhoot bolte hain* (Vajpayee is a liar)." And the tone set almost eight years ago still defines the environment of confrontation and conflict. With the marginalisation of leaders with magnanimous hearts and the rise of those who have status but no stature, the nation is heading for bigger confrontations. The new year hints enough about things to come, and confrontationists steeped in their little conceits are waiting for the right moment to play out the script of disruptive politics. ■